6.2 Times tables: activities

← Unit overview

1. What I already know

You need: a printed or hand-drawn 10 × 10 times-table grid (rows and columns 1–10), three coloured pencils.

1. Colour every fact in the ×1, ×2, ×5 and ×10 rows and columns green. "These you already know or can work out fast."
2. Colour the square facts (2 × 2, 3 × 3 … 10 × 10) yellow.
3. Point out that 6 × 7 and 7 × 6 are the same (*omdraaien*). Colour only one of each pair.
4. Count the facts left over. There aren't many!

Talk about it: "How many facts did you think you had to learn? How many are there really?"

2. Arrays everywhere

You need: egg boxes, a muffin tin, Lego bricks (the studs make arrays), a chocolate bar with squares, a window with panes.

Find things in rows and columns around the house. For each: "How many rows? How many in each row? How many altogether?" Write the multiplication: a 6-egg box is 2 × 3.

Then build: "Make 4 × 6 with Lego. Now turn it around. Is it still 24?" Split the array: "Can you show 4 × 6 as 4 × 5 and 4 × 1?" This is exactly the "one more group" strategy.

Talk about it: "Why is 3 × 8 the same as 8 × 3? Can you show me with the bricks?"

3. Doubling chains

You need: paper, coins (optional).

Start with a ×2 fact and keep doubling:

`2 × 7 = 14` → `4 × 7 = 28` → `8 × 7 = 56`

Use €1 coins or €2 coins to show it. Make a chain for each number from 3 to 9. Stick the chains on the fridge.

Talk about it: "If you know 4 × 6 = 24, what is 8 × 6? What's 16 × 6?" (The last one is a stretch; let him try if he likes.)

4. Patterns on a 100-grid

You need: a 1–100 grid (draw it, or print one from Sommenfabriek), coloured pencils.

Colour the 9 table. What pattern do you see? (A diagonal line. The tens go up and the ones go down: 9, 18, 27, 36…) Do the same for the 5 table (two columns) and the 4 table.

Talk about it: "Why do the 9s make a diagonal?" (Each time you add 10 and take 1 away.)

5. My tricky-facts box

You need: small cards, an envelope or box.

Write each fact he finds tricky on a card, with the question on the front and on the back **his own strategy** to work it out (for example "7 × 8: 5 × 8 = 40, 2 × 8 = 16, together 56"). Go through the

box once or twice a week, without a timer. When a card has been easy three times, it “graduates” and goes in a “done” envelope.

The “done” envelope getting fatter is the point. Show him.

Talk about it: “Which strategy do you use the most?”

6. Tables in the shop

You need: a supermarket folder or a real shopping trip.

- “Yoghurt drinks come in packs of 6. We need 4 packs. How many drinks?”
- “Apples cost €0.50 each (50 cents). How much for 8?”
- “Three packs of 8 sausages: enough for 20 people?”
- “Cans cost €2 each. We have €18. How many can we buy?”

Talk about it: “Where do you see times tables outside school?”

Conversation prompts (any time)

- “Which table do you like best? Why?”
- “What’s your favourite trick for the 9 table?”
- “Is there a number that’s in both the 4 table and the 6 table?” (12, 24, 36…)
- “Can a number in the 5 table end in 3?”